

A Work of Artifice



SUMMARY

The miniaturized tree in its pretty pot could have grown soaringly tall in its natural habitat, only stopping when struck by lightning. Instead, a gardener has meticulously cut the tree back; it's only nine inches tall. Every day, as the gardener prunes this tiny tree, he soothingly tells it that it was always meant to be a tiny, sweet, feeble, indoor sort of plant—and that it's lucky that it grows in such a nice pot. If you want to stunt a living creature's growth, the speaker says, you have to start early: binding feet, limiting thought, curling hair to produce the kind of soft hands that you love touching.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-24



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-8

*The bonsai tree ...
... nine inches high.*

The first lines of “A Work of Artifice” describe the alternative life a “bonsai tree” could have led in the wild (a bonsai tree is a miniature ornamental tree grown in a way that prevents it from reaching a normal size). Left to its own devices, the speaker says, this tree might have gotten to be “eighty feet tall,” growing out of the “side of a mountain” and ending its life dramatically (and glamorously) “split by lightning,” as if being struck down by the gods. In this life, the tree would have been mighty, energetic, and grand; the idea that it would die in a lightning strike suggests that it might have risen high above everything around it on its mountainside perch. This is not, however, the life this tree has had. Instead, it sits in an “attractive pot.” A gardener has “carefully pruned it” and managed its growth, keeping it eternally “nine inches high.”

The poem's shape mirrors this sense of restrained energy and potential. Written in [free verse](#) (without a regular [meter](#) or a [rhyme scheme](#)), “A Work of Artifice” uses [enjambments](#) to prune back the description of the tree in lines 1-5:

The bonsai tree
in the attractive pot
could have grown eighty feet tall
on the side of a mountain
till split by lightning.

This description of how big the tree *could* have gotten is one big sentence restrained by line breaks, so that even the longest line is a mere six words long. When the speaker eventually describes how big the tree is now, they do so in one clipped-off [end-stopped line](#): “It is nine inches high.”

This bonsai tree—with its huge, energetic potential “pruned” into something tiny, reserved, and “attractive”—will become Marge Piercy's [symbol](#) for the life of a woman in a patriarchal society. Stereotypical femininity, the poem will suggest, is a “work of artifice” imposed on women by an oppressive male-dominated world.



THEMES



SEXISM, PATRIARCHY, AND OPPRESSION

Through the [symbolic](#) image of a gardener pruning a bonsai tree, “A Work of Artifice” suggests that a patriarchal, male-dominated society oppresses women first by restricting their power, then by convincing them they never had that power to begin with. The poem kicks off with a description of a tree that could have grown to be “eighty feet tall” if it were left in its natural habitat on the “side of a mountain.” Instead, a gardener has “carefully pruned” it so that it is only “nine inches tall” and can live indoors in an “attractive pot.”

The gardener keeps the tree in this stunted condition in two ways: by “whittl[ing] back its branches,” and by telling the tree that its artificial tininess is in fact its natural state. “It is your nature,” he tells it, “to be small and cozy / domestic and weak.” The [irony](#) of these words is plain! The tree still has so much wild natural energy that the gardener has to cut it back “every day”; he's trying to make the tree *believe* that it's small to make his job easier. He even tells the tree that it's “lucky” he's provided it this nice pot to live in, falsely implying that it wouldn't make it a day without him.

The bonsai's predicament, the speaker observes, is precisely the condition in which women the world over find themselves. Through beauty standards from hair curlers to foot-binding, through restrictions that stunt women's “brains,” and through just-so stories about women's inherent “weak[ness]” and domesticity, a male-dominated culture represses women's energy and potential, keeping them trapped in limited lives. This sharply ironic poem (first published in 1970 as a broadside, a one-sheet poem to be distributed like a flyer) calls on women to realize that their power is much, much greater than they've been told.

LINES 9-16

*Every day as ...
... to grow in.*

The bonsai tree's [symbolic](#) significance becomes clearer in lines 9-16. Here, the gardener “whittles back” the tree’s branches and “croons” to it, as if singing it a lullaby. This vision seems strangely tender until readers listen to what the gardener is actually telling the tree:

It is your nature
to be small and cozy,
domestic and weak;

These lines ooze [irony](#): in reality, it *isn't* the tree's nature to be small, and the gardener has to “whittle” its branches back “every day” to make sure it doesn't outgrow its “attractive pot.” The very fact that he feels compelled to remind the tree that it's inherently “small,” “domestic,” and “weak” suggests that he's pretty worried about what might happen if the tree figured out that none of this is true!

The [parallelism](#) of “small and cozy, / domestic and weak” slowly reveals what the gardener most fears. Each of these qualities is the opposite of what the tree really is—and the repetitive phrasing means that the concluding word “weak” stands out. “Small,” “cozy,” and “domestic” can all have neutral or positive connotations, but “weak” is an outright insult, and one that casts a shadow over the rest of those descriptors. This concluding word also makes it clear that the gardener *really doesn't want* the tree to realize that it is, in fact, strong.

To cap his creepy lullaby off, the gardener stresses how “lucky” the tree should feel to have the nice little “pot” he's provided it to “grow in.” Here, he's suggesting that the tree is dependent on his generosity and care: it would never have made it without him.

Everything the gardener says is the precise opposite of what's true—and it's also exactly what a patriarchal society tells women. The speaker doesn't have to spell this out for readers to grasp the point. The mere use of the words “small and cozy, / domestic and weak” signals that the bonsai tree is being indoctrinated with the same falsehoods that women get told about their “natural” way of being in the world. The tree's manicured tininess becomes an image of repressed female energy.

LINES 17-24

*With living creatures ...
... love to touch.*

The speaker now steps back from the scene of the gardener and the bonsai tree to make a more general pronouncement about what it takes to stunt a “living creature[]” and persuade it that it lacks the power it most certainly possesses. “One must

begin very early,” the speaker observes in a tone of icy [irony](#), if one wants to “dwarf [the] growth” of any living being: in other words, the indoctrination has to happen right from the start, or no one would be fooled by it.

Note that the speaker carefully does not say they're talking about women in particular here. They let a list of restrictions and abuses (strung together with neat [anaphora](#)) reveal that for them:

the bound feet,
the crippled brain,
the hair in curlers,
the hands you
love to touch.

The parallel phrasing here lines up a series of rather different ways in which women have been forced to conform to male ideals. At first, readers might wonder about some of these [juxtapositions](#):

- “Bound feet” refers to a longstanding traditional practice in China (now, nearly extinct) in which women's feet were broken, folded in on themselves, and left to heal into tiny pointed nubs: almost impossible to walk on and a source of lifelong agony, but perceived to be beautifully dainty and feminine.
- “Hair in curlers” sounds pretty benign by contrast! But the point the speaker is making here is that beauty standards—*any* beauty standards—are part of a more general project to restrict women's “brain[s]” by making them believe that their role in the world is solely to be “cozy,” “domestic,” “attractive”: decorative and limited as the bonsai tree.

The final entry in this list drives this point home. “The hands you / love to touch,” like the gardener's “croon[ing],” might at first sound almost tender. But all the agency, all the power, is in the hands that are doing the touching, not the hands that are being touched. As the gardener “loves” the pretty little bonsai tree, so does a sexist man “love” a woman: as an enjoyable object, not an independent person who might like to use her hands to do her own bidding. These closing words tie a bow on the poem's [extended metaphor](#). The sexism of a male-dominated world, this poem suggests, works by simultaneously “pruning back” women's inherent power and persuading women that they never had that power to begin with.

Marge Piercy first published this poem as a broadside (a one-sheet publication meant to be passed around like a flyer) in 1970, right in the thick of the second-wave feminist movement. This is a poem with a powerful political purpose in mind, asking women to wake up and realize that they have huge energy and potential stored up inside them—including the power to break

out of whatever “attractive pot” they’ve been unwittingly and unwillingly planted in.

to the bonsai tree.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Line 20:** “the bound feet,”
- **Line 22:** “the hair in curlers,”



SYMBOLS



THE BONSAI TREE AND THE GARDENER

In “A Work of Artifice,” a stunted bonsai tree [symbolizes](#) oppressed women. The gardener who stunts that tree, meanwhile, symbolizes the male-dominated culture that holds women back.

The poem’s bonsai tree, the speaker observes, would have grown to be “eighty feet tall” in the wild; it’s full of power and energy. The tree has been denied the chance to use those qualities to the full, however. That’s because a “gardener” has instead put the tree in an “attractive pot” and carefully “pruned” it, “whittl[ing] back the branches” so that it can never grow beyond “nine inches tall.” He tells the tree that it’s its “nature / to be small and cozy, / domestic and weak.”

This, the poem suggests, is precisely what a society designed and ruled by men tells women about their natures, their lives, and their capabilities. The gardener simultaneously restricts the tree’s capacity to grow and tells the tree that it never could have grown; his assault on the tree’s powers is both physical and psychological.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-16



BOUND FEET AND HAIR IN CURLERS

To stunt the growth of a “living creature[,]” the speaker says, one has to start early with a program of “bound feet” and “hair in curlers.” These two very different beauty standards nonetheless work together to [symbolically](#) suggest all the different demands a patriarchy makes of women’s bodies—demands that the speaker feels drain the energy and possibility from women’s lives.

A male-dominated society, the speaker observes, refuses to accept women’s bodies in their natural state. Women are meant to be attractive to men, and being attractive always seems to mean spending a lot of time and energy changing themselves. Whether making themselves beautiful means having their feet broken into a more “pleasing” shape or wearing curlers in their hair for hours every night, at least one part of the result is the same: women are *artificially* reshaping themselves to suit someone else’s ideal (and not using their energy for their own purposes).

Such demands, the speaker suggests, are all ways in which a patriarchal culture hampers women’s ability to think and act for themselves, a kind of “pruning” just like what the gardener does



HANDS

The “hands” in the poem’s closing lines quietly [symbolize](#) agency and power—an agency and power that a patriarchal society denies to women with its demands for quiet, “cozy,” “domestic” prettiness and obedience.

There are two sets of hands implied in the poem’s closing lines: “the hands you / love to touch,” and the hands that are doing the touching. One set of hands here is acting on the other set of hands, which just sit there passively, waiting to be stroked.

This image encapsulates the gender dynamic that this poem attacks. A sexist world insists that women should be merely decorative, spending their time making sure they’re desirable. Their hands—which they might use to perform all sorts of impressive feats—are reduced to pretty, passive objects for men to enjoy.

The hands in this poem thus represent the power to act and to change the world. The poem’s speaker seems to urge women to look at their own hands, asking what they might be able to *do* with them beyond getting a manicure.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Lines 23-24:** “the hands you / love to touch.”



POETIC DEVICES

ENJAMBMENT

Through [enjambments](#), the speaker matches this poem’s form to its subject matter. The first eight lines of the poem, for example, use enjambment to shape the description of the life the bonsai tree could have led:

The bonsai tree
in the attractive pot
could have grown eighty feet tall
on the side of a mountain
till split by lightning.
But a gardener
carefully pruned it.
It is nine inches high.

The first five lines here are all a single sentence. But through enjambments, that sentence is *pruned back* into tiny

segments—just as the gardener “carefully prune[s]” the tree itself. (Notice, too, the way the speaker ends this passage with one short [end-stopped line](#)—“It is nine inches high”—that likewise mirrors the tiny, stunted tree it describes.) Similar enjambments appear all across the poem, keeping the verse as restrained and orderly as the poor tree.

The poem’s enjambments affect its tone, too. Consider the speaker’s reflections in lines 17-19:

With living creatures
one must begin very early
to dwarf their growth:

These line breaks create a deliberate, measured pace, drawing attention to the speaker’s strange (and meaningful) sentence structure. In everyday speech, you’d be more likely to start with the *subject* of the sentence, the “one”: “One must begin very early to dwarf a living creature’s growth.” Here, instead, the speaker begins with the “living creatures,” the *object* of the sentence, then works their way backward to the unsettling verb “dwarf”: readers have to think about the reality of “living creatures” (living *women*, the speaker implies) before discovering that they’re fated to be stunted by a patriarchal society so pervasive that it’s only presented as an abstract “one” here. The enjambments break this slow, grim reveal out into careful stages.

Where Enjambment appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-2:** “tree / in”
- **Lines 2-3:** “pot / could”
- **Lines 3-4:** “tall / on”
- **Lines 4-5:** “mountain / till”
- **Lines 6-7:** “gardener / carefully”
- **Lines 9-10:** “he / whittles”
- **Lines 12-13:** “nature / to”
- **Lines 17-18:** “creatures / one”
- **Lines 18-19:** “early / to”
- **Lines 23-24:** “you / love”

IRONY

The poem’s [irony](#) first comes through in the speaker’s description of the bonsai tree and its repressive gardener. The little tree sits in an “attractive pot,” the speaker observes, and the gardener has “carefully pruned it” to make sure it will never grow beyond “nine inches high.” He “croons” to it like a father singing a lullaby, telling the bonsai tree that it’s its “nature” to be “domestic,” “small,” and “weak.” Of course,, nothing the gardener says to the tree is true: he has to work hard “every day” to make sure that the bonsai doesn’t remember its inherent power and grow to “eighty feet tall”! All his apparent gentleness appears is laced with deep irony: he is, in fact, not being tender and loving but rather rigid and restrictive.

This speaker’s voice drips with irony as well, and it’s by holding back her direct opinion of the way that patriarchy stunts women’s lives that she reveals *exactly* what she thinks. She reflects:

With living creatures
one must begin very early
to dwarf their growth:

On their face, these words sound like a neutral observation: if you want to make a “dwarf” creature, you have to start reshaping it early in its life. But the speaker’s clear sympathy for the tree that could have grown “eighty feet tall” if left to its own devices means these lines feel icily ironic. The speaker is here diagnosing a societal evil in a reserved tone, suggesting that the cruelty of the way the world holds women back speaks for itself.

Where Irony appears in the poem:

- **Lines 9-16:** “Every day as he / whittles back the branches / the gardener croons, / It is your nature / to be small and cozy, / domestic and weak; / how lucky, little tree, / to have a pot to grow in.”
- **Lines 17-19:** “With living creatures / one must begin very early / to dwarf their growth:”
- **Lines 23-24:** “the hands you / love to touch.”

PARALLELISM

[Parallelism](#) makes the speaker’s words sound more forceful as she observes the workings of patriarchal sexism. The first moment of parallelism arrives in the gardener’s speech to the bonsai tree:

It is your nature
to be small and cozy,
domestic and weak;

The swing of these parallel phrasings helps to capture the gardener’s condescending “croon”: it’s as if he’s singing a sinister lullaby to the bonsai tree, coaxing it into complacency. The shape of these lines also frames the word “weak”: “small,” “cozy,” and “domestic” don’t sound so bad (even if none of them is inherently true of the bonsai tree), but “weak” is the key word here, the big degrading lie that the gardener tells the tree—and that a male-dominated society tells women.

Later on, the speaker’s reflection on the tools with which the world stunts women’s growth uses emphatic [anaphora](#) to suggest a connection between different forms of oppression:

the bound feet,
the crippled brain,
the hair in curlers,

the hands you
love to touch.

The parallelism here helps to suggest that “bound feet,” “curled hair,” and a “crippled brain” all play a part in sexism. Though curling your hair might not seem as oppressive as breaking and reshaping your feet, both beauty demands force women (like bonsai trees) to assume a shape pleasing to men—and go hand in hand with a “crippled brain,” a mind prevented from reaching its full potential. These ideas all come together in the closing image of the “hands you / love to touch”: women’s hands become decorative things that men get to enjoy, not instruments with which the women themselves can act.

Where Parallelism appears in the poem:

- **Lines 13-14:** “to be small and cozy, / domestic and weak;”
- **Lines 20-24:** “the bound feet, / the crippled brain, / the hair in curlers, / the hands you / love to touch.”



VOCABULARY

Bonsai tree (Lines 1-2) - A tree that has been pruned and cultivated so that it only grows to a miniature height. Bonsai is a traditional Japanese art form.

Pruned (Lines 6-7) - Trimmed, cut back.

Whittles (Lines 9-10) - Shaves with a knife.

Croons (Lines 9-11) - Speaks soothingly, softly, and sweetly.

Domestic (Lines 12-14) - Living indoors, tamed.

Dwarf (Lines 17-19) - Stunt, make small.

Bound feet (Line 20) - An [allusion](#) to a traditional Chinese practice in which women's feet were broken and folded into tiny triangles known as “lotus feet.” (This practice has now all but died out.)

Crippled (Line 21) - Debilitated, disabled. (While the word “crippled” is now treated as a slur, it was a more neutral descriptor at the time that Piercy wrote the poem.)

been eighty feet tall” if it weren't restrained) is a mere six words long; most of the poem is written in lines of just three or four words.

This choice has a double effect. The clipped, careful lines reflect what a male-dominated society does to the women the “dwarf” bonsai tree represents: holding them back, restraining their growth, frustrating their energies. But they also suggest a massive energy ready to burst out of these bonds. The poem is built from just five sentences broken into many lines—a choice that suggests there’s plenty of power coiled up and waiting to unfurl in all the women who have been held back by societal sexism.

METER

The poem is written in [free verse](#), so it doesn't use a regular [meter](#). Instead, the speaker uses [enjambments](#) to cut the poem's short lines to roughly equal lengths, much as the oppressive gardener cuts back the bonsai tree. Take a look at the way lines 1-5 flow, for example:

The bonsai tree
in the attractive pot
could have grown eighty feet tall
on the side of a mountain
till split by lightning.

This is one long sentence doled out a few words at a time; like the “bonsai tree” it describes, the language here feels clipped and restrained—not by aggressive “prun[ing],” but by line breaks.

The small irregularities in line length also mimic a bonsai tree. Ranging from three to six words long, the lines feel contained and regimented, but not precisely uniform. There’s room for something a *little* organic in this kind of growth, the poem's shape implies—but that doesn't mean that the tree (or the repressed and frustrated women it represents) have room to grow as wild and strong as they could.

RHYME SCHEME

This [free verse](#) poem doesn't use a [rhyme scheme](#). Rather than making a political point in harmonious, musical verse (as, for instance, Christina Rossetti did in her [sonnet](#) “[In an Artist's Studio](#)” or Thomas Hardy did in his arch poem “[The Ruined Maid](#)”), Piercy instead delivers this poem in a clipped, straight-ahead voice heavy with icy [irony](#). There's no melody here, whether thoughtful or sarcastically lively: just a slow, deliberate description of a slow, deliberate process of oppression.

The lack of rhyme here also suits the poem's central [symbol](#) of the bonsai tree. Bonsai (the practice of pruning and shaping trees to keep them at a miniature scale) is a traditional Japanese art form, and the kinds of Japanese verse most familiar to Western audiences (such as haiku and senryu) are



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

The form of “A Work of Artifice” is an [allegory](#): the gardener's pruning of the bonsai tree [symbolizes](#) patriarchal oppression of women. The poem's form on the page also mirrors a careful, frustrating, and repressive process of restraint. Its 24 lines of [free verse](#) (poetry without a regular [rhyme scheme](#) or [meter](#)) are all “carefully pruned,” just like the manicured bonsai tree the poem uses as a symbol of oppressed women. The very longest line (fittingly, line 3, which describes how the tree “could have

also unrhymed.



SPEAKER

The poem's speaker doesn't reveal anything directly about who they are. The reader nevertheless gets the impression that the speaker is a person enraged by the way in which society stunts women's natural energies. In the larger context of Marge Piercy's feminist poetry, readers might reasonably take this speaker as a voice for Piercy herself.

The speaker's description of a gardener talking to the bonsai tree he's pruning back—he tells it its nature is to be "small and cozy, / domestic and weak"—is an angry critique of a certain kind of male attitude toward women, and indeed a *cultural* attitude toward women. The gardener's condescension masks the fact that it is *he* who is forcing the tree to be a cute little houseplant in an "attractive pot" rather than the eighty-foot behemoth it might have become in the wild. The speaker's attitude toward such insidious forms of repression is clear: she's furious, though her language is never less than icy and controlled.

Outraged with a world that stunts women, the speaker also seems to be warning women of the ways in which a patriarchal, male-dominated culture might try to "dwarf" them. She cautions, for instance, against oppressive, painful, and labor-intensive beauty standards ("bound feet," "hair in curlers"), efforts to control and reshape the body that are ultimately meant to produce restricted, hampered "brain[s]."



SETTING

There's no one clear setting in this poem: its story criticizes a whole male-dominated world. While the speaker's vision of a bonsai gardener touches on a traditional Japanese practice of growing miniature trees, and her mention of "bound feet" [alludes](#) to a traditional (and now mercifully extinct) Chinese practice of breaking women's feet to reshape them into tiny, pointed "lotus feet," the poem doesn't have a specifically Asian setting. The idea here, rather, is that women face sexist oppression the world over.

The poem's images of stunting and reshaping are part of a general critique of the way that patriarchy "cripple[s] brain[s]," cutting off women's energy and stopping them from reaching the heights they could in a different world. "Bound feet," "hair in curlers," and sexist ideals of "domestic" coziness, the poem suggests, are all facets of the same repressive culture. Women everywhere are taught (or forced) to be humble and decorative—and to abandon or deny their inherent energy and strength.

Piercy wrote this poem in 1970, and it might be read as a voice from the midst of the second-wave feminist movement in

America. Piercy played a vocal part in second-wave feminism as a writer and an activist. She first published this poem as a broadside, a single sheet of paper meant to be distributed like a flyer; this is a work with a clear political purpose, grounded in a time of protest.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

Marge Piercy (1936-present) is an American poet and novelist from Detroit, Michigan. Piercy, who always felt at odds with society's narrow expectations for women of her generation, became deeply involved in the second-wave feminist movement of the 1960s and '70s. Many of her works reflect her convictions. She first published "A Work of Artifice," for instance, as a broadside in 1970 (that is, a one-sheet poem intended to be distributed like a flyer); this is a poem with a marked political purpose.

Asked about the role of feminism in her life and work, [Piercy replied](#):

Why am I a feminist? I was born a woman. I can't imagine not identifying strongly as a woman and not wanting things to be better and safer and more fun and less dangerous for myself and other women.

Piercy began her poetic career in a time when writers were making bold new experiments in form and producing forthright political works. Some of her contemporaries include the Confessionalist poet [Sylvia Plath](#), the memoirist [Maya Angelou](#), the feminist journalists [Betty Friedan](#) and Gloria Steinem, and the Beat poet [Allen Ginsberg](#). While politically iconoclastic, Piercy deeply values poetic tradition and heritage, describing herself as a distinctly American poet in the tradition of [Emily Dickinson](#) and [Walt Whitman](#). As she says on her website: "Everything truly American since is a descendent of theirs." She was also influenced by English Romantic poets like [Keats](#), [Coleridge](#), and [Byron](#) and by the modernist poet [T. S. Eliot](#).

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

This poem comes out of the heart of the second wave of feminism—that is, the resurgence of feminist energy that followed the initial Suffragist push for women's voting rights in the late 19th and early 20th centuries.

The American branch of second-wave feminism sprung up in the 1960s, partly in reaction to the cultural conservatism of the 1950s. During World War II (which ran from 1939 to 1945), American women had had the chance to do work they'd never had before, taking jobs vacated by soldiers. (Think of the famous poster of [Rosie the Riveter](#): a patriotic image of a woman helping to build military airplanes.) In the 1950s, a

socially conservative backlash against these kinds of changes demanded that women get out of the workplace and back into the home, where they were meant to live the kind of “small and cozy” domestic lives this poem’s insidious “gardener” represents as ideal and natural.

But women began to rebel against these restraints—and against a culture that defined their worth by how much they appealed to male sensibilities. This poem’s link between “curled hair” and “crippled brains” makes a point that became important to the feminist thinkers of this era: that narrow beauty standards were part of women’s oppression, labor-intensive (and indeed “Artific[ial]”) demands that trained women to think of themselves as strictly decorative and subordinate.

Second-wave feminists fought for—and won—a wide range of new rights for women, including the 1963 Equal Pay Act (which mandated that women and men must be paid the same amount for the same jobs) and the 1965 Supreme Court decision *Griswold vs. Connecticut* (which required that women should have free access to contraception). But some of the advances they sought—like the adoption of the wide-ranging Equal Rights Amendment, a proposed constitutional amendment that would codify the equal treatment of men and women—remain ongoing feminist struggles.

- [The Poem as a Broadside](#) — See an image of the poem as it was originally published: as a broadside, a one-sheet flyer meant to be easily distributed. This is a form that reflects the poem's political purpose. (<https://www.betweenthecovers.com/pages/books/503671/marge-piercy/broadside-a-work-of-artifice>)
- [Piercy's Website](#) — Visit Piercy's personal website to learn more about her work. (<https://margepiercy.com/poetry>)
- [The Poem Aloud](#) — Listen to a reading of the poem. (<https://youtu.be/Ycm7pTfZwUY?si=L5c6adwLsTige5z0>)
- [An Interview with Piercy](#) — Watch an interview with Piercy in which she discusses the politics of her art (among other topics). (https://youtu.be/zN64zGhN4RM?si=majaNz4JSYF_rdvt)



HOW TO CITE

MLA

Nelson, Kristin. "A Work of Artifice." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 14 May 2024. Web. 22 May 2024.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Nelson, Kristin. "A Work of Artifice." LitCharts LLC, May 14, 2024. Retrieved May 22, 2024. <https://www.litcharts.com/poetry/marge-piercy/a-work-of-artifice>.



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [More on Piercy](#) — Learn about Piercy's life and work in this short Poetry Foundation biography. (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/marge-piercy>)